A Taste of Honey: Understanding the Text

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

Download PDF

Written by: Sam Evans
Updated on 1 October 2025

All questions in the IGCSE encourage an informed personal response, which means that it is not enough just to know the text you are being examined on really well; you also need to develop a sound understanding of the themes, main ideas, settings, situations and events in the play you have studied, as well as an understanding of the significance of a particular moment or scene in relation to the whole text. You also need to demonstrate an awareness of the text as a piece of drama and show an appreciation of the play on stage. All of this will help you to develop a sustained, critical understanding of the text, which will allow you to demonstrate individuality and insight.

Each of the sub-topics below will help you to develop a better understanding of the text:

- Historical context
- Social context
- Literary context

A Taste of Honey historical context

Shelagh Delaney was born in 1938 in Manchester, northern England. As a teenager, Delaney was inspired to write a play that depicted **working-class** lives in a realistic way as a response to typically idealised portrayals of traditional, **middle-class** England. Her play A Taste of Honey, written in 1958, explores British society after World War II. By setting the play in the impoverished industrial city of Salford in the north of England, Delaney examines the impact of poverty and class.

Postwar Britain

- After World War II, as a result of economic ramifications, Britain improved upon social care systems by introducing a **Welfare State** and a free health care system:
  - **Working-class** families were especially hard hit in war-torn Britain
  - They found it hard to get secure work or earn enough to become socially mobile
  - Inexpensive housing was limited, and, in industrial areas such as the North of England, properties were often run-down, without heating or lighting

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it

being wives and mothers
    - Women were expected to be faithful, although it was (mostly) acceptable for husbands to have affairs within marriage
    - The contraceptive pill was prescribed for the first time in 1961, but only to married women

How this links to A Taste of Honey	
Poverty and class	In the exposition, Helen and Jo move into a small flat in an industrial area in Salford, Lancashire. The flat is near a "slaughterhouse" and the "gasworks". It has no heating, a leaking roof, a community bathroom, and Jo and Helen share a bed. Helen tells Jo that she cannot afford anything better. Peter Smith, a **middle-class** car salesman, on the other hand, has a "big, white house" and describes the area in which Helen and Jo live as "ghastly". When he says, "Nobody could live in a place like this", Helen replies, "Only about fifty thousand people". Delaney critiques **middle-class** values when a pregnant Jo is not invited to the "dazzling white house" in which Peter lives.
The traditional nuclear family	Delaney breaks traditionally idealised depictions of a **nuclear family**. Her main characters are two single mothers, Helen and her daughter, Jo. Delaney illustrates the social stigma attached to single motherhood through her **hypocritical** character Peter. He insults Helen for her **promiscuity** while having a wallet full of women's pictures. He marries Helen to provide her with financial security, only to abandon her and her daughter.

Help me understand

A Taste of Honey social context

Shelagh Delaney's honest portrayal of systemic racism, sexism, and **homophobia** in 1950s Britain was considered controversial when it was first performed. At the time, film and theatre was mostly confined to portrayals of **middle-class**, white, heterosexual families.

Racism

- After the war, there was increased immigration to Britain, such as in the shape of the **Windrush generation**
- This immigration was met with mixed responses:
    - Interracial relationships were generally frowned upon, and British people in relationships with other races were often **ostracised** and abused

jobs in the military
    - In 1948, when the **National Health Service** was established, Caribbean and Asian immigrants were often recruited as nurses and porters

Homophobia

- Postwar Britain's **patriarchal** standards left little room for relationships that were not heterosexual or conducted within the sanctity of marriage
- Attitudes towards homosexual men led to discriminatory practices
- In 1958, when A Taste of Honey was written, homosexual acts between men were illegal in Britain
- Many homosexual men sought safety from prosecution and jail in heterosexual relationships

How this links to A Taste of Honey	
Racism	Delaney reflects systemic racism through her character the "Boy" (Jimmie). The script mentions that he was a nurse before he joined the navy. Jimmie's comments that Jo is one of the only white girls he knows who does not mind that he is Black represents the social barriers existing at the time. The play's portrayal of a young white girl having a relationship with a Black boy was considered controversial at the time.
Homophobia	Delaney's homosexual character Geof has never kissed a girl before, but his eagerness to marry Jo represents his desire for the safety of a heterosexual relationship. He is **marginalised**: he has been evicted by his landlady although refuses to discuss the reason with Jo. Geof's isolated character highlights the result of social prejudices and pressure to conform. He is verbally abused by Helen and Peter with typically **homophobic** references to his sexuality, such as "pansified little freak". Jo's friendship with Geof is presented sympathetically: he is the only character in the play who supports Jo with her pregnancy.

A Taste of Honey literary context

Before World War II, British theatre and film was mostly limited to optimistic comedies depicting wealthy characters. Plays like A Taste of Honey were created as a backlash to this. They are considered social commentary in their portrayal of the lives of poor, ordinary young **working-class** individuals in a

away from polished portrayals of life.

Kitchen sink drama

- A Taste of Honey is considered a forerunner of **kitchen sink dramas**, along with John Osborne's 1956 play **Look Back in Anger**
- **Kitchen sink dramas** usually aim to depict dissatisfaction and resentment among the **working class**:
  - The name refers to the domestic lives of those living in run-down, rented accommodation
- Protagonists are often young, poor, and angry at a society in which they feel powerless:
  - Characters speak in **regional dialects** and accents other than **Received Pronunciation**
  - They often reflect pub culture — miserable characters seeking refuge in alcohol
- The genre's popularity continued into the 21st century and is notably found in television soap operas

How this links to A Taste of Honey	
Kitchen sink drama	Delaney's play is set in an industrial area in the North of England: Helen and Jo live in a flat that is "falling apart", and they speak in **regional dialect**, expressing harsh and angry sentiments. Delaney portrays a young, **working-class** girl who is neglected by her neglectful and unstable single mother. Helen drinks too much and conducts casual affairs. The play depicts a disillusioned, poverty-stricken and underfed family who struggle with resentful feelings about their lot in life.

Sources

Delaney, Shelagh (2008), *A Taste Of Honey* (Edited by Glenda Leeming and Elaine Aston), Bloomsbury Academic.

Pidd, Helen (11 March 2024), "'Unbelievably relevant': what can the explosive 1958 play A Taste of Honey tell us today?" *The Guardian*, https://www.theguardian.com/stage/2024/mar/11/explosive-a-taste-of-honey-shelagh-delaney-salford-single-mother, accessed 12 September 2025.

Teacher only

Test your students on this in just a few clicks

- Create exam-aligned tests
- Tailor format & difficulty

Test yourself

Was this revision note helpful? Yes No

Previous Next

Course Study tools All topics

Resources

Learning Hub
Scholarship
Join
Past Papers
Solution Banks
Sitemap

Dashboard

Overview
Brand ambassador
Profile
Subscription
Settings
Log out

Company

About us
Exam Specificity
Content Quality
Promotions
Jobs
Terms
Privacy
Cookie Policy
Help and Support

Subjects

Biology
Chemistry
Physics
Maths
Geography
English Literature
Psychology
All Subjects

© Copyright 2015–2026 Save My Exams Ltd. All Rights Reserved.